



MANY HOUSEBOATS, WHOSE RENTALS TOUCH RS 15,000 A DAY, DISCHARGE SEWAGE AND KITCHEN WASTE DIRECTLY INTO THE BACKWATERS

MORE THE DIRTIER: Nearly 200 of the 700 houseboats are unlicensed out thousands of empty plastic bottles and sent back 2,000 of them to companies like Coca Cola and Pepsi in a day. Within a week, 75,000 pet bottles were collected and sent back to the companies. The project, however, did not last long due to lack of cooperation from the authorities.

Problems like poor drainage system, shortage of land for dumping waste, inadequate public toilets and shortage of water continue to haunt Kovalam. Unauthorised constructions have been going on with impunity. According to a study, the tourism industry was responsible for more than 28 per cent of violations of coastal regulation zone (CRZ) laws in Kovalam. Of this, 26 per cent violations were in the No Development Zone demarcated by CRZ laws. Today hotels stand so close to the sea that one can step into the waters directly from the hotel rooms.

The panoramic backwaters are fast turning into environmental cesspools. The main culprits are the houseboats, a huge draw for tourists. At the last count, there were about 700

houseboats plying on the backwaters in Alappuzha and Kumarakom though only about 500 have the required licences. The quality of boats differs as they range from the premium segment that have five-star comforts, and fetch a daily rent of up to Rs 20,000 to ordinary ones which costs about Rs 500 a day. But what is common to most houseboats is the lack of effective waste disposal system. Most of them merrily discharge sewage and kitchen waste directly into the waters causing heavy damage to the estuarine and backwa-

ter ecosystems. Besides, there is the contamination of the waters by diesel and kerosene from the boat engines. According to a study, a film of oil is fast spreading over the waters in Punnamada and Kumarakom where many houseboats anchor.

It was only after environmentalists made the right noises that the government made biochemical sewage treatment tanks mandatory for all boats. Jojoy Mathew of Rainbow Cruises says biochemical sewage tanks fitted in boats are not effective enough. "The only way out is to have big sewage plants installed on land to which boats should bring their waste to be treated. As this was too costly for individual boat owners, the government had promised to build common sewage treatment plants to be used by all. But it is yet to be done". Cijo Alex, director of the group, says the company has set up a dedicated high-tech sewage plant at a cost of Rs 25 lakh into which their boats directly release the waste for treatment.

Another problem is the frenetic construction activity in the state. Kumarakom in Kottayam has been a

RUSH HOUR		
YEAR	FOREIGN	DOMESTIC
2006	4.3	62.7
2005	3.5	59.5
2004	3.5	59.7
2003	2.9	58.7
2002	2.3	55.7
2001	2.1	52.4

Tourist arrivals in Kerala. Figures in lakhs.